

Psalms 76

God Known in Judah

In Judah is God known: his name is great in Israel
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *In Judah is God known: his name is great in Israel.*
- 2 *In Salem also is his tabernacle, and his dwelling place in Zion.*
- 3 *There brake he the arrows of the bow, the shield, and the sword, and the battle. Selah.*
- 4 *Thou art more glorious and excellent than the mountains of prey.*
- 5 *The stouthearted are spoiled, they have slept their sleep: and none of the men of might have found their hands.*
- 6 *At thy rebuke, O God of Jacob, both the chariot and horse are cast into a dead sleep.*
- 7 *Thou, even thou, art to be feared: and who may stand in thy sight when once thou art angry?*
- 8 *Thou didst cause judgment to be heard from heaven; the earth feared, and was still,*
- 9 *When God arose to judgment, to save all the meek of the earth. Selah.*
- 10 *Surely the wrath of man shall praise thee: the remainder of wrath shalt thou restrain.*
- 11 *Vow, and pay unto the LORD your God: let all that be round about him bring presents unto him that ought to be feared.*
- 12 *He shall cut off the spirit of princes: he is terrible to the kings of the earth.*

2 · CONTEXT

A victory hymn, likely composed after a dramatic deliverance from an invading army (some Jewish tradition ties it to Sennacherib's defeat, though the text does not name the event). Its focus is less on the mechanics of the battle than on the terror and awe that God's decisive intervention produces even among nations who did not previously acknowledge Him. Henry emphasizes that such deliverances are meant to make God's name known, not merely to relieve the immediate threat.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

God is declared known and great specifically in Judah and Israel—His dwelling place is Salem (Jerusalem), His tabernacle in Zion. The opening frames the whole psalm as a testimony to a particular, located, historical revelation of God's greatness, not an abstract theology.

Verse 4-6

God is described as more glorious than the mountains of prey—stronger than the fiercest predatory powers. The stout-hearted enemy is spoiled, plunged into a deep, deathlike sleep; even chariot and horse are cast into stillness by a mere rebuke. Military might is shown as utterly powerless before God's word.

Verse 7-12

The psalm turns to reverent awe: who can stand before God when He is angry? Judgment was heard from heaven, causing the earth itself to fear and fall silent when God arose to save the meek of the earth. Even human wrath, in the end, ends up serving God's praise, since He restrains what remains of it. The closing call is to make vows and pay them, bring gifts to the One who is to be feared—terrible in majesty to the kings of the earth.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Dramatic deliverance is never merely about relief; it is meant to make God's greatness unmistakably known—first to His own people, then to watching nations. The same power that shatters chariots and armies also acts specifically to save the meek and oppressed, revealing that God's terrifying majesty and His tender protection of the humble are not in tension but united in one character.

Application for life today.

When you experience a decisive deliverance—large or small—resist the temptation to move on quickly without letting it testify to God's greatness, both to yourself and to others. Let this psalm reshape how you think about power: the most fearsome strength in the universe is precisely what stands ready to save the meek. Consider what vow or tangible response of gratitude (v. 11) is

appropriate after God has clearly acted on your behalf.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Can you recall a deliverance in your own life that, like this psalm, deserved to become a lasting testimony rather than a quickly forgotten relief?

2. How does holding together God's terrifying majesty (vv. 7–8) and His tenderness toward 'the meek of the earth' (v. 9) shape your view of Him?

3. What vow, gift, or response of gratitude might God be calling you to actually pay, rather than merely feel (v. 11)?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).